

Materia Medica III

Parasite-Expelling & Topical Application Herbs

This handout contains two sections:

1. Herbs That Expel Parasites

- Bing Lang
- Da Fu Pi

2. Topical Application Herbs

- Liu Huang
- She Chuang Zi
- Xue Jie

SECTION 1

Herbs That Expel Parasites

Category Overview

Herbs that expel parasites are primarily used to treat intestinal parasitic infections. According to Bensky, these herbs must be carefully matched to the type of parasite, the patient's constitution, and the presence of accumulation or deficiency patterns.

These herbs often:

- kill or expel intestinal parasites
- move accumulation downward
- alleviate abdominal pain
- address accompanying qi stagnation or damp obstruction

Typical symptoms of parasitic infection include:

- peri-umbilical abdominal pain
- appetite changes
- vomiting
- anal itching
- fatigue with emaciation

Global Characteristics

Characteristic	Description
Taste	Often bitter or acrid
Temperature	Variable (often warm or cold)

Characteristic	Description
Primary Channels	Spleen, Stomach, Large Intestine
Core Actions	Kill parasites, move accumulation, relieve abdominal pain

Global Safety Cautions

- Contraindicated during pregnancy
- Use caution in weak patients or Spleen deficiency
- Strong doses may cause nausea, vomiting, dizziness, or diarrhea
- These herbs are typically taken on an empty stomach to improve the antiparasitic effect

Quick Reference Table – Parasite Expelling Herbs

Herb	Nature	Channels	Key Functions
Bing Lang	Acrid, bitter, warm	ST, LI	Expels parasites, especially tapeworms; drains downward
Da Fu Pi	Acrid, slightly warm	SP, ST, LI, SI	Moves qi, reduces abdominal distention and edema

Bing Lang (檳榔)

Semen Arecae Catechu | Betel nut

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, Bitter, Warm

Channels: Stomach, Large Intestine, Spleen, Liver

Primary Actions

1. Kills parasites (especially tapeworms)
2. Drains downward and reduces accumulation
3. Moves qi and reduces abdominal distention
4. Promotes urination and reduces edema

Key Indications

- Tapeworm infestation
- Abdominal distention with food stagnation
- Constipation due to accumulation
- Damp leg qi with edema

Cautions/Contraindications

- Use cautiously in Spleen deficiency
- Avoid in pregnancy

- Strong downward action can damage qi in weak patients

Preparation

- Typically decocted
- Often taken on an empty stomach to enhance antiparasitic activity.

Dosage

6–15 g in decoction

Large doses (60–120 g) may be used in severe tapeworm infestation protocols

Exam Pearl

Bing Lang = the strongest parasite herb that ALSO moves qi downward.

Clinical Insight

Bing Lang is both an antiparasitic and a qi-moving herb, making it useful when parasites coexist with food stagnation or abdominal distention.

Bing Lang strongly drives parasites downward and is therefore often combined with other herbs that weaken parasites.

Da Fu Pi (大腹皮)

Pericarpium Arecae | Betel nut husk

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, Slightly Warm

Channels: Spleen, Stomach, Large Intestine, Small Intestine

Primary Actions

1. **Moves qi and alleviates abdominal distention**
2. **Promotes urination and reduces edema**

Key Indications

- Abdominal distention due to qi stagnation
- Edema from damp obstruction
- Damp accumulation with qi stagnation

Cautions/Contraindications

- Use cautiously in qi deficiency
- Not a true antiparasitic herb despite its botanical relationship with Bing Lang

Preparation

- Usually decocted
- Sometimes added later to preserve aromatic qi-moving action

Dosage

6–12 g decoction

Exam Pearl

Da Fu Pi = qi-moving peel of Bing Lang → treats distention + edema.

Da Fu Pi treats damp obstruction with qi stagnation, while Bing Lang directly expels parasites.

Clinical Insight

Although related botanically to Bing Lang, Da Fu Pi is primarily a qi-moving herb rather than a direct antiparasitic herb.

SECTION 2

Topical Application Herbs

Category Overview

Topical application of herbs is primarily used to treat external disorders affecting the skin, tissues, and localized areas of the body. These herbs act through direct absorption into the skin and local tissues.

They are commonly used to treat:

- skin infections
- itching disorders
- parasites and fungi
- traumatic injuries
- chronic ulcers or wounds

Many topical herbs are toxic and must be used carefully.

Forms of Application

Common preparation methods include:

Topical preparations

- powders
- ointments
- pastes
- plasters
- creams

External liquid preparations

- herbal washes
- decoction washes
- mouth gargles
- steam inhalation

Local instillation

- eye drops
- ear drops

Some herbs may also be used internally if specifically indicated.

Global Characteristics

Characteristic	Description
Primary Use	External application
Common Actions	Kill parasites, stop itching, detoxify, heal tissue
Mechanism	Local absorption through skin and membranes
Preparation	Powders, pastes, ointments, washes

Global Safety Cautions

- Many topical herbs are toxic
- Avoid large surface areas
- Avoid broken skin or open wounds unless specifically indicated
- Avoid sensory orifices
- Risk of systemic toxicity increases with damaged skin

Quick Reference Table – Topical Herbs

Herb	Toxic	Dermatology	Trauma	Core External Uses
Liu Huang	Yes	Yes	—	Kills parasites, treats scabies, and fungal infections
She Chuang Zi	No	Yes	—	Stops itching, dries damp, kills parasites
Xue Jie	No	—	Yes	Generates flesh, heals wounds

Liu Huang (硫黃)

Sulphur | *Sulfur* (toxic)

Nature & Flavor: Sour, hot, toxic

Channels: Kidney, Large Intestine, Pericardium

Primary Actions

1. Kills parasites and stops itching (topical)
2. Relieves toxicity
3. Tonifies Ming Men fire (internal use)
4. Unblocks bowel movement

External Indications

- Scabies
- Ringworm
- Damp sores
- Fungal infections
- Chronic itching lesions

Internal Indications

- Kidney yang deficiency
- Cold constipation
- Asthma from Kidney failing to grasp Qi

Cautions/Contraindications

- Contraindicated in pregnancy
- Contraindicated in yin deficiency with heat
- Toxic in large doses

Preparation Methods

- Powder applied directly
- Powder mixed with sesame oil for topical application
- Incorporated into ointments

Dosage

- Internal-1–3 g powder in pill form
- Topical- Powder applied directly or mixed with oil

Exam Pearl

Liu Huang = classic topical treatment for scabies and fungal infections

Clinical Insight

Liu Huang is unusual because it is both a topical antiparasitic and an internal Kidney yang tonic.

She Chuang Zi (蛇床子)

Fructus Cnidii | Cnidii fruit

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, bitter, warm

Channels: Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Dries dampness and stops itching**
2. **Kills parasites**
3. **Warms Kidney yang (internal)**
4. **Disperses wind-cold**

Internal Indications

- Impotence
- Infertility from Kidney yang deficiency

External Indications

- Itchy skin disorders
- Genital itching
- Weeping lesions
- Damp eczema

Commonly used for itching of the genital region caused by damp pathogens.

Forms of Application

- Herbal wash
- Powder
- Ointment

Cautions/Contraindications

- Yin deficiency with heat
- Damp-heat in the lower burner

Preparation

- Decoction used as a topical wash
- Powder used for ointments

Dosage

- Internal: 3–10 g
- External wash: 15–30 g

Exam Pearl

She Chuang Zi = genital itching herb

Clinical Insight

This herb is both a Kidney yang tonic AND a dermatology herb, making it particularly useful for damp genital itching with underlying deficiency.

Xue Jie (血竭)

Sanguis Draconis – Dragon’s Blood Resin

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, salty, neutral

Channels: Heart, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Invigorates blood and alleviates pain (internal)**
2. **Generates flesh and heals wounds (external)**
3. **Stops bleeding**

Internal Indications

- Blood stasis pain
- Traumatic injury
- Amenorrhea with masses

External Indications

- Chronic non-healing ulcers
- Traumatic injuries
- Contusions and fractures
- Painful wounds

Cautions/Contraindications

- Avoid in pregnancy
- Use cautiously in patients with bleeding disorders

Preparation Methods

- Powder applied directly
- Mixed with herbal plasters or pastes
- Often combined with Ru Xiang and Mo Yao

Dosage

- Internal: 1–1.5 g powder
- External: topical powder or plaster

Exam Pearl

Xue Jie = “dragon’s blood” → heals wounds and moves blood.

Clinical Insight

Unlike many topical herbs, Xue Jie works both internally and externally to treat trauma and blood stasis.

Clinical Comparisons

Herb	Key Distinction
Bing Lang	Strong parasite-expelling herb
Da Fu Pi	Moves qi and reduces edema
Liu Huang	Powerful topical antiparasitic and antifungal
She Chuang Zi	Topical antiparasitic for genital itching
Xue Jie	Promotes tissue regeneration and wound healing